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12 October 2026

Asia Edge: IMF handshakes and inflation flares

This is an overview of key economic and market-relevant developments in Asia Edge economies. It is part of the our weekly EM Edge Data Watch link

Mahmoud Harb

- Pakistan reached an SLA with the IMF on the program review...
- … with the Fund calling for the removal of the new fuel subsidy scheme.
- Sri Lanka also secured an SLA, with Board approval conditional on budget plans
- Vietnam is witnessing a domestic demand-led growth upsurge...
- ...but overheating risks are rising amid policy easing and cost-push inflation.
- Mongolia's inflation accelerated, driven by higher fuel prices

Pakistan: SLA reached with IMF; subsidy removal potentially contentious

Pakistan and the IMF reached on October 7 a staff-level agreement (SLA) on the fourth review of the 2024-2027 Extended Fund Facility (EFF) arrangement. IMF Board approval would unlock about US$1.21bn in total financing. Our baseline assumes Board approval by end-2026, although delays are possible if the IMF has made it conditional on subsidy removal or other prior actions (PA), as discussed below.

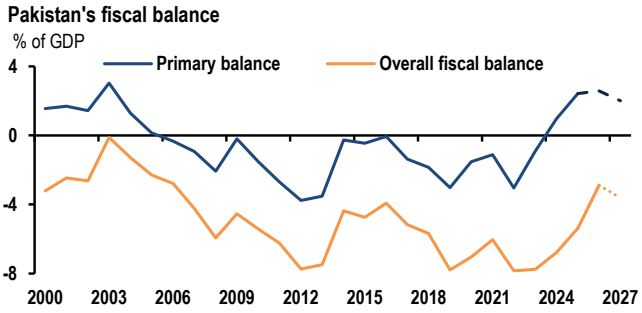
The confirmation of the primary surplus target of 2% of GDP for the current FY2026/27, despite the challenging global environment, reaffirmed the authorities' commitment to adjustment policies. We expect the target to be met, despite the risk of renewed tax revenue shortfalls. This would mark the fourth consecutive year of primary surpluses, Pakistan's strongest fiscal performance since 2005.

Critically, the IMF called for the prompt phasing out of the recently introduced fuel subsidy scheme, judging it costly and poorly targeted. We recently discussed the mechanism and highlighted the high risks of cost overruns and leakages (see our note). However, removing the subsidy mechanism may prove contentious, as the authorities have elevated it to a key policy response to the shock amid ongoing tensions with the opposition. It remains unclear whether its elimination is a PA for completion of the review.

The SLA did not indicate any PAs for Board approval, but these could have been agreed upon without being disclosed. This was the case for the third review, when the collection of overdue tax claims and a fuel price adjustment were included as PAs but not mentioned in the SLA press release. According to media reports (link), a PA was proposed on the amendments of the laws on ten SOEs to bring them in line with the SOE act. This is a structural benchmark initially due for June 2025 that was missed and reset to August 2026. It appears to have been missed again.

More broadly, the IMF's assessment was positive but nuanced. It noted that the program remains "*broadly on track*," highlighted that "*strong policies*" have helped Pakistan remain resilient amid a challenging global environment, and underscored the authorities' commitment to sound macroeconomic policies. The IMF also welcomed recent rating upgrades and the authorities' plans to develop the domestic government securities market and diversify the investor base.

The IMF also reiterated its longstanding advice for the State Bank of Pakistan to maintain an appropriately tight monetary policy stance and ensure exchange rate flexibility. It reemphasized its policy prescription for addressing the electricity sector's financial weaknesses through privatizations, price adjustments, and measures to tackle inefficiencies.



Source: IMF, J.P. Morgan

Sri Lanka: SLA on penultimate program review; 2027 budget and post-program in focus

Sri Lanka and the IMF reached a staff-level agreement (SLA) on October 4 on the seventh and penultimate review of the ongoing 2023-2027 program.

IMF Board approval, which would unlock a US$345mn disbursement, is conditional on two standard prior actions: the presentation to Parliament of a 2027 Budget aligned with program targets and the completion of the financing assurances review to confirm multilateral partners' financing contributions and assess progress with debt restructuring. The budget process is ongoing with the Appropriation Bill receiving its

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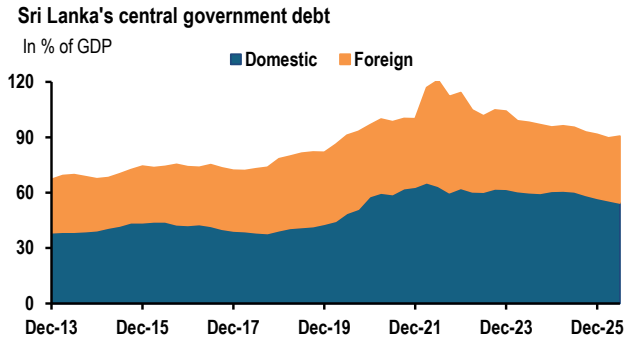
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first reading in Parliament on Oct 7. The budget speech is scheduled for Nov 12, followed by the final parliamentary vote on November 20. We expect the IMF Board to approve the review by late November or early December.

Sri Lanka's performance under the IMF program has been strong. The program ends next March, and we believe a successor arrangement will be needed given still high government debt, low reserve adequacy, and the country's untested return to international markets following its debt restructuring. The government is still weighing its options and has reportedly indicated that it may consider a stand-by arrangement (link; link)., which we believe investors would view positively.

However, signs of reform fatigue are emerging. The government recently announced that the property tax included in the program's policy agenda will not feature in the 2027 Budget (link) and has signaled potential VAT relief in 2-3 years (link).



Source: Central Bank of Sri Lanka, J.P. Morgan calculations

Vietnam: Growth surges, solid outlook but rising risks

See our full notes on Vietnam's recent outturns for growth here, inflation here and BoP here

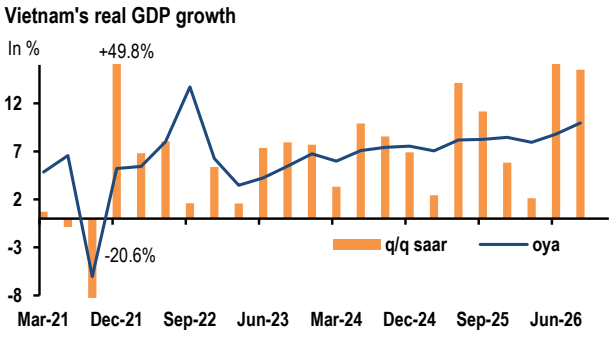
The JPM view: A slate of data releases in Vietnam in recent days have highlighted a surging growth momentum, a temporary deterioration in the current account, and fuel-driven acceleration in inflation. We have revised our growth and inflation forecasts upwards in 2026 to 9% and 4.6% respectively, and our current account balance forecast down to a small 0.2% of GDP deficit. The investment push, resilient manufacturing and FDI support a strong medium-term outlook and leave upside risks to our growth forecasts. However, above-target inflation and a weaker current account will test the limits of coordinated policy easing, which leaves the economy at the risk of overheating.

Domestic demand powers the expansion

Vietnam's GDP expanded by a breakneck 9.95%oya in 3Q26, broadly matching the government's 10% target and lifting growth over the first three quarters to 9%. The 3Q growth outturn compares with 8.8% y/y in 2Q and comfortably exceeded the 8.7% consensus forecast. Since 2009, growth at this pace has been surpassed only in 3Q22, when the economy rebounded from the pandemic slump. This time, the acceleration came from an already elevated base, suggesting activity may be exceeding the economy's near-term capacity. We have revised our 2026 growth forecast to an above-trend 9%, second only to Taiwan in Asia, while retaining our 7% forecast for 2027 despite unfavourable base effects. Vietnam's competitiveness, continued attractiveness for FDI and planned large-scale investments should ease infrastructure bottlenecks and sustain medium-term growth.

Domestic demand drove the acceleration, supported by policy easing, rapid credit growth and a large infrastructure push. Investment surged 21.4%oya, apparently led by domestic private investment, while consumption grew 9%. Exports rose a robust 23.3%, but imports increased even faster at 28.8%, consistent with Customs data (*more on this below*). On the supply side, industry, led by manufacturing, and services contributed almost equally to the acceleration.

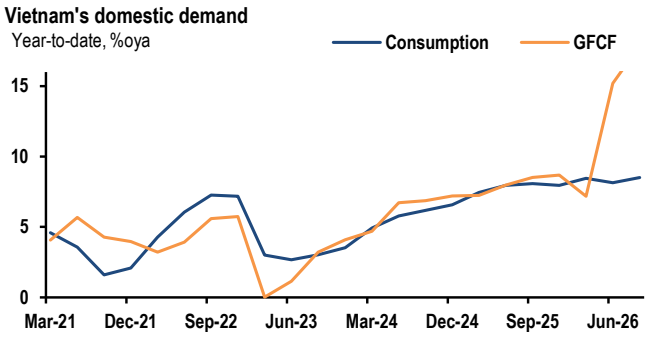
In terms of momentum, GDP growth eased modestly to 15.5% from 16.8% on a q/q seasonally adjusted annualized basis (saar). Agriculture slowed, while mining and construction contracted, although the latter should prove temporary given the strength of investment and the pipeline of planned projects. Services gathered pace, with wholesale and retail trade and financial services together contributing around 4 percentage points to sequential growth, consistent with buoyant spending and credit activity.



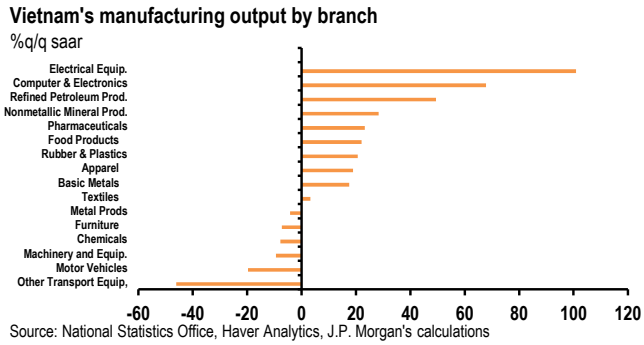
Source: General Statistics Office of Vietnam, J.P. Morgan

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Source: General Statistics Office of Vietnam, J.P. Morgan

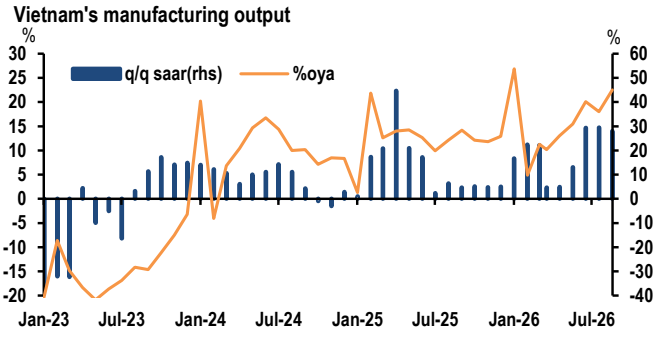


Source: National Statistics Office, Haver Analytics, J.P. Morgan's calculations

Manufacturing ends 3Q with strong momentum

Vietnam's manufacturing production rose 22.5%oya in September, its fastest annual pace in four years excluding January distortions around the timing of the Lunar New Year Tết, while sequential growth reached 30.5% q/q saar. Electrical equipment, computers and electronics continued to post exceptionally strong growth. A broad range of other sectors, including refining, mineral products, pharmaceuticals, agribusiness, rubber and plastics, and clothing and apparel, also recorded solid, albeit more moderate, gains. Meanwhile, activity remained subdued in machinery and equipment, the automotive industry, textiles and furniture.

The S&P Global Manufacturing PMI slipped to 51.9 as output and new-order growth moderated and export orders moved further into contraction. Output prices continued to decline even as input costs rebounded with global oil prices, pointing to a potential squeeze on margins.



Source: General Statistics Office of Vietnam, J.P. Morgan

Inflation returns above target

Vietnam's headline inflation rose to 5.1% in September from 4.9% in August, slightly below our 5.2% forecast, while m/m inflation held around 0.5% sa. Core inflation edged down to 4.4% from 4.5%, its fourth consecutive month of broad stability. Higher transport costs more than offset softer food inflation as average gasoline and diesel prices rose 11.8% and 4.2%, respectively, from August. The government extended fuel-tax relief for another three months, absorbing part of the increase, but early-October fuel prices rose by a similar magnitude relative to September averages.

Assuming oil follows the futures curve, we expect headline inflation to peak at 5.6% in October, ease to 4.9% in December and average 4.7% in 2026. We forecast a decline to 3.2% in 2027, driven mainly by lower oil prices, steady growth and a stable exchange rate. Core inflation should average 4.4% in 2026 and 4.3% in 2027. Risks remain tilted upward. Oil volatility is high, El Niño and below-average rainfall (see our note) could lift food prices, and rapid credit growth, fiscal easing and strong activity could broaden price pressures.

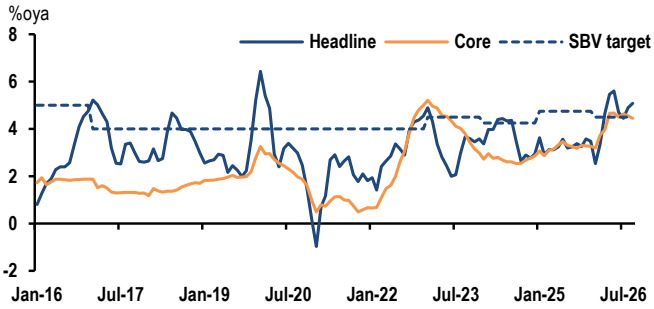
The SBV has kept the refinancing rate at 4.5% despite inflation remaining above its 4.5% target since March, although liquidity operations and interbank rates provide a better guide to the effective stance than the policy rate alone. The overnight interbank rate has averaged 3.1% since the beginning of September down from 4.2% during July-August, reflecting a more accommodative liquidity management by the central bank.

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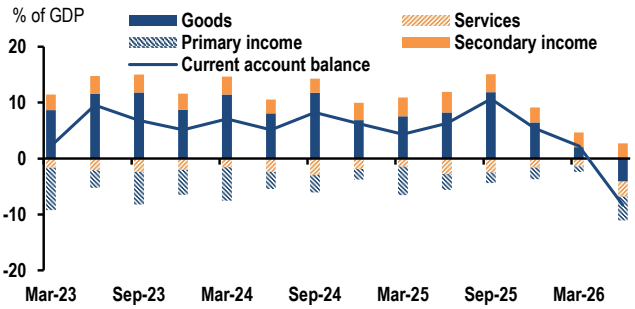
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Vietnam's inflation



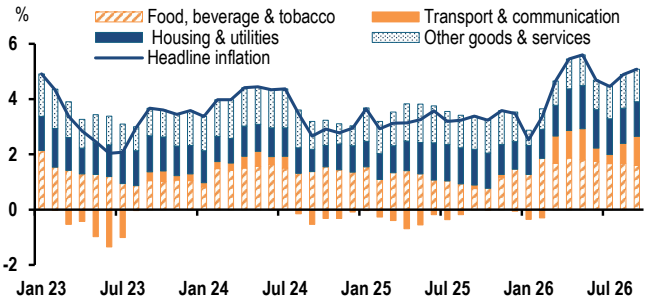
Source: General Statistics Office of Vietnam, SBV, J.P. Morgan

Vietnam's main current account components



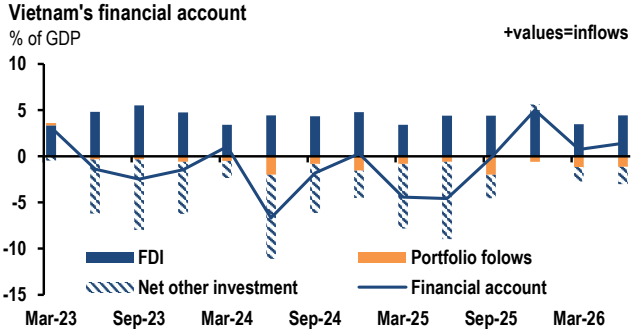
Source: State Bank of Vietnam, Vietnam's General Statistics Office, J.P. Morgan

Contributions to Vietnam's annual inflation



Source: General Statistics Office of Vietnam, J.P. Morgan 's calculations

Vietnam's financial account



Source: State Bank of Vietnam, Vietnam's General Statistics Office, J.P. Morgan

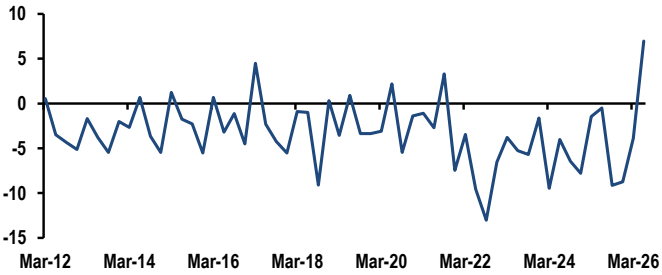
The BoP deficit that was not

Vietnam's current account (CA) swung to a record US$11.1bn, or 8.3% of GDP, deficit in 2Q26 from a US$7.5bn surplus a year earlier. The trade balance moved from a US$9.8bn surplus to a US$5.5bn deficit as imports soared 39.1%oya to 111.9% of GDP, outpacing a 22.7% rise in exports to 107.8% of GDP. Electronics dominated both sides. The services deficit was broadly stable at 2.7% of GDP, the primary income deficit widened to 4.2% of GDP, and the secondary-income surplus reached 2.7%, likely supported by remittances. FDI remained strong at 4.4% of GDP, while portfolio outflows were 1.1% of GDP.

A US$9.3bn, or 7% of GDP, errors and omissions (E&O) inflow offset most of the CA deficit. Vietnam has historically recorded large unaccounted outflows, averaging 5.3% of GDP over the past three years, making the reversal in 2Q26 particularly striking. There is no clear smoking gun, but three explanations appear plausible and complementary: exports may be under-recorded amid growing gaps between Vietnamese and partner-country trade data (see our note), intragroup trade credit used to finance electronics imports may not have been fully captured, and previously unrecorded outflows may have slowed or reversed as enforcement tightened around crypto assets, gold and diamonds, and higher deposit rates increased the appeal of VND assets.

Vietnam's BoP errors and omissions

Non-seasonally adjusted, % of GDP



Source: State Bank of Vietnam, General Statistics Office of Vietnam, J.P. Morgan

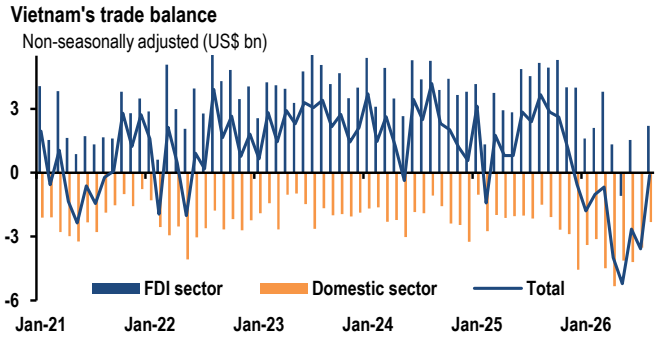
Trade improves, but uncertainty remains high

Vietnam's monthly Customs data point to an improvement entering 3Q. The trade balance posted a US$1.3bn surplus in September, its first positive reading in 10 months, as export momentum accelerated to 52% 3m/3m saar from 41% in June and import momentum slowed to 35% from 66%. Export growth of 39.2%oya remained overwhelmingly driven by electronics and tech products, up 74.3%, with machinery and equipment a distant second. Imports rose 45.8%, again led by electronics. The moderation in electronics imports could reflect the unwinding of earlier front-loading, but it may also signal a softer export cycle, consistent with two months of contraction in the PMI new export orders index.

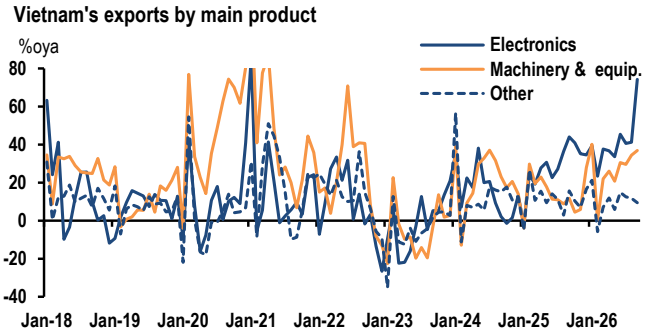
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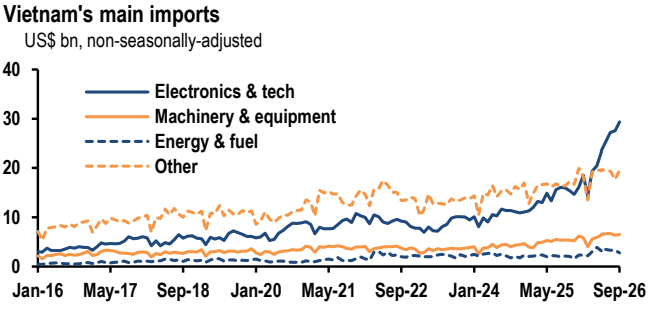
We forecast a US$2.4bn, or 1.7% of GDP, CA surplus in 3Q and have revised our full-year forecast to a 0.2% of GDP deficit from a 0.5% surplus. We continue to expect a 2.9% of GDP surplus in 2027, but confidence around the path is low. Oil price volatility, El Niño-related risks to food production, rainfall shortages and import demand associated with infrastructure projects all tilt the near-term risks lower. We project FX reserves at US$89bn at end-2026, up from US$86.1bn in July, supported by the external balance and increased corporate and bank borrowing overseas, although inherently volatile E&O flows remain a major source of uncertainty.



Source:Statistics Office of Vietnam/Vietnam General Department of Customs, J.P. Morgan



Source: National Statistics Office of Vietnam, J.P. Morgan's estimates



Source: Vietnam's General Department of Customs, J.P. Morgan

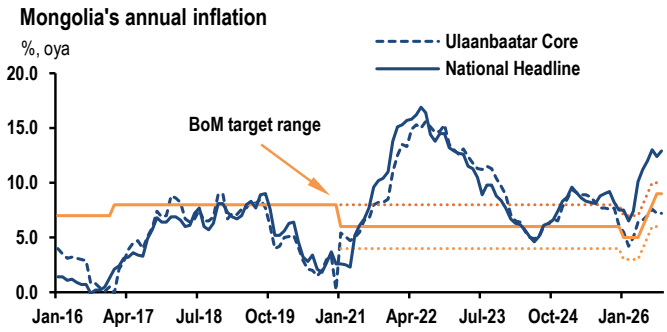
Mongolia's inflation rises again on higher fuel costs

Mongolia's headline CPI inflation accelerated to 12.9%oya in September from 12.4%, driven by higher transport costs. Meanwhile, Ulaanbaatar's core inflation, which excludes the most volatile items, remained steady at 7.2%.

Transport inflation rose to a four-year high of 15.2%oya, reflecting higher fuel prices amid disruptions to Russian supply following Ukrainian attacks. These disruptions have led to shortages in Mongolia and increased reliance on more expensive alternative sources. Meanwhile, food inflation eased to a six-month low of 20.8%oya, reflecting base effects and a possible normalization in meat prices. Earlier harsh weather conditions had decimated livestock herds, driving a sharp rise in meat prices that was the main driver of the acceleration in inflation.

We lift our forecast for average inflation in 2026 to 10.6% from 10.5%. We expect inflation to end the year at 11.7% and remain in double digits well into until 2Q27. Risks to our baseline are tilted to the upside, reflecting the continued lack of normalization in fuel supply and ongoing fiscal easing through tax cuts and wage and pension increases. While the case for rate hikes is strengthening, we still expect the Bank of Mongolia (BoM) to remain on hold for the rest of 2026 as core inflation remains steady. However, we see increased risks of another hike in late 2026 or early 2027 if inflation remains high, and particularly if core inflation accelerates.

The BoM kept its policy rate unchanged at 12.5% at its September 17 meeting, in line with our expectation. The decision followed an off-cycle 50bp rate hike and a 50bp increase in the MNT reserve requirement ratio in August. The next policy announcement is scheduled for December 17.



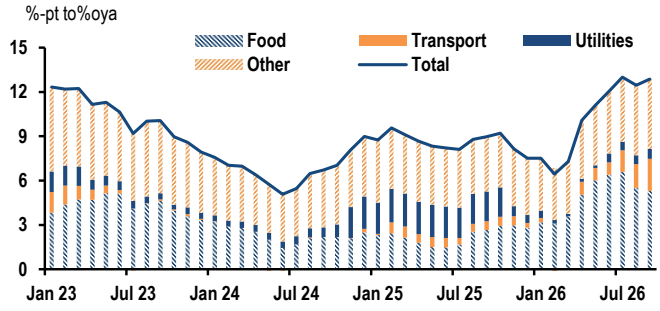
Source: Bank of Mongolia, J.P. Morgan

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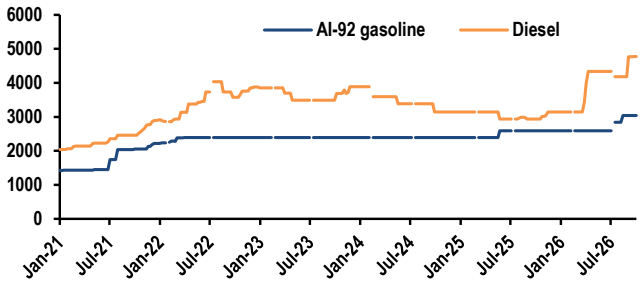
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Contributions to Mongolia's CPI inflation



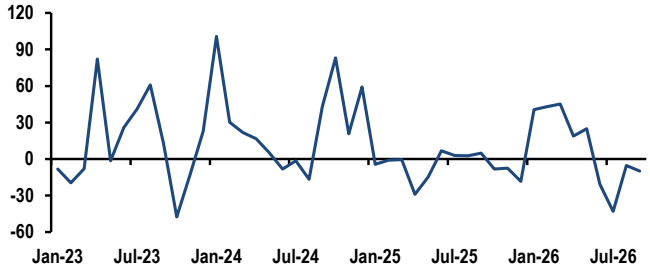
Source: Mongolia's National Statistics Office, J.P. Morgan

Mongolia's retail fuel prices



Source: National Statistics Office of Mongolia, J.P. Morgan

Mongolia's imports of petrol



Source: Mongolia's National Statsitics Office, J.P. Morgan

Data releases and forecasts

Week of Oct 12 - Oct 16

No data releases scheduled

Review of past week's data

No past data releases for review.

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